

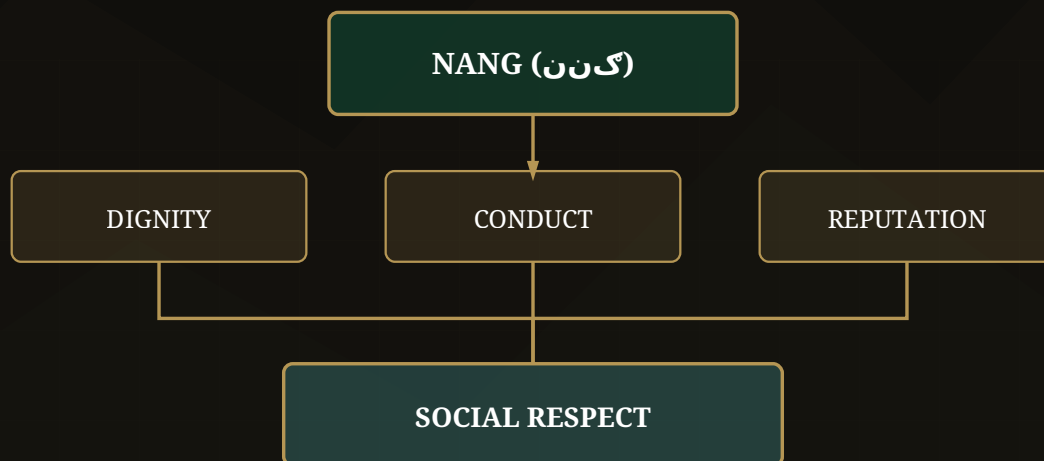
NANG — HONOUR

“Dignity Is Not Only How Others See You — It Is How You Carry Yourself”

Dignity Conduct Reputation Responsibility Respect

In the vocabulary of Pashtunwali, few ideas carry as much emotional and social weight as nang (ننگ).

The word is commonly translated into English as “honour,” but translation alone cannot capture the full cultural meaning. As scholarly studies by M. Jamil Hanifi and Lutz Rzehak emphasize, nang is connected to dignity, reputation, honourable conduct, and the responsibility to live according to values recognized by one's community. It is not simply about being respected; it is also about behaving in a way that makes respect possible.¹



“Honour is produced through conduct, not merely claimed through status.”

NANG VS. VIOLENCE AND BADAL

A critical distinction in anthropological research is separating nang from violence or retaliation. While popular media often collapses Pashtun honour into revenge, academic studies—including Mikhail Pelevin's historical analyses—differentiate between Nang (honourable conduct and moral standing) and Badal (reciprocity or retribution in response to injury). Nang encompasses hospitality, keeping one's word, protection, and social responsibility, far exceeding the scope of conflict response.²

NANG (Honour)

Dignity • Responsibility
Honourable Conduct

BADAL (Reciprocity)

Response to Injury
Redress & Balance

“Nang is a broad ethical framework of conduct; Badal specifically concerns response to injury.”

HONOUR, TRUST, AND PROFESSIONAL INTEGRITY

In contemporary life, the principles underlying nang translate into professional and civic integrity. Keeping one's word, taking responsibility for commitments, and treating others with respect form the modern continuation of traditional honour. As Nancy Hatch Dupree notes in

her encyclopaedic treatments of Afghan etiquette (*ādāb*), interpersonal respect and social trust remain central pillars of cultural identity.³

DIGNITY · CONDUCT · RESPONSIBILITY · TRUST

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

For me, Nang is not about being feared. It is about being trusted. It is not about proving that you are stronger than everyone else, but about proving that you can carry responsibility without losing yourself. Today, I see honour in keeping my word, in respecting my family, in building something useful, and in carrying the name Orakzai without allowing the past to limit the future. That is the kind of honour I want to carry forward.